Agree With Your Siblings How You'll Choose Care for Your Mother Someday

Four prompts to put your mother's wishes first, find where the family actually disagrees, draft the ground rules for a future decision, and write down what would have to be rechecked before anyone chose.

Where you are

Your mother is well, and nobody is choosing anything. But you've seen other families fall apart over a decision made in a week, and you'd rather the siblings agree now on how you'll decide than argue later about what.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say what matters most to your mother, where the family agrees and where it doesn't, how you'll share information when the time comes, and what would need fresh confirmation before any real choice.

A one-page Family Decision Agreement draft: What matters most to your mother, What matters to each of us, How we'll share information and talk, What we'll recheck before any choice, and What we've agreed not to do yet.

Before you start

- Anything your mother has said about how she wants to live and who she wants involved.
- A sentence from each sibling about what they'd care about most, if you can get it.
- A sense of where everyone lives and how available each of you really is. Two of these three is plenty.

PROMPT 1

Put your mother's wishes on paper first

WHY THIS MATTERS

The family's criteria should start with hers. If her words aren't written down, the loudest sibling's priorities will quietly become the family's.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What your mother has said about her future, in her words if you can remember them.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my mother has said, over the years, about how she wants to live as she gets older and who she wants involved in decisions:

> [PASTE WHAT SHE HAS SAID]
>
> Turn it into a short list under WHAT MOM HAS TOLD US, keeping her words where I've given them. Then list WHAT WE'VE ASSUMED SHE WANTS and WHAT WE SHOULD ASK HER DIRECTLY. For the last list, write each item as a question one of us could ask her in an ordinary conversation. Don't infer her wishes from her age or health, and don't suggest where she should live.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The things you've assumed for years that she has never actually said.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask her the first question on the list, alone, and write down her answer in her words.

PROMPT 2

Find out where the family actually disagrees

WHY THIS MATTERS

Siblings often believe they agree until the first real option appears. Collecting each person's priorities separately, then laying them side by side, surfaces the differences while they're still easy to talk about.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A few lines from each sibling or involved relative about what would matter most to them, and your mother's list from Prompt 1.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Each person in my family wrote a few lines about what would matter most to them in a future care arrangement for our mother. Here they are, labeled by person, followed by what your mother herself has said:
>
> [PASTE EACH PERSON'S LINES]
>
> [PASTE MOM'S LIST FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> Make a table with one row per concern and one column per person, marking where each person raised it. Then list: WHERE WE AGREE, WHERE WE DIFFER, and WHAT NOBODY MENTIONED THAT MOM RAISED. Describe the differences neutrally, as different priorities, not as right and wrong. Do not pick a side or suggest a compromise.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Differences that are really about distance, money, or guilt rather than about your mother.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Send the table to everyone before you discuss it, so nobody is surprised in the conversation.

PROMPT 3

Draft the ground rules for a future decision

WHY THIS MATTERS

A process agreed in calm is easier to follow in a crisis. Who gathers information, how it's shared, who sits in the conversation, and what you won't do yet are all things you can settle now.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of Prompts 1 and 2, and who in the family lives where.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my mother wants, where my siblings and I agree and differ, and where each of us lives and how available we are:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 AND 2]
>
> [PASTE WHO LIVES WHERE AND THEIR AVAILABILITY]
>
> Draft ground rules for how our family would make a care decision for your mother if one became necessary, under: HOW WE'LL GATHER AND SHARE INFORMATION, WHO WILL BE IN THE CONVERSATION (always including your mother), HOW WE'LL HANDLE DISAGREEMENT, and WHAT WE AGREE NOT TO DO YET. Write them as proposals for the family to edit. Do not say who has or should have legal authority to decide, and do not assign roles to people beyond what I've described.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A rule about disagreement that puts your mother's stated wishes ahead of a head count.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the draft aloud on a family call and change whatever doesn't sound like you.

PROMPT 4

Write the agreement to come back to

WHY THIS MATTERS

This page isn't a plan for a move. It's the family's agreement about how it will decide, kept with your mother's wishes and a list of what will have to be confirmed fresh when the time comes.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from Prompts 1 to 3.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything my family has worked out about how we would choose care for our mother someday:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write a one-page Family Decision Agreement draft with five headings: WHAT MATTERS MOST TO MOM, WHAT MATTERS TO EACH OF US, HOW WE'LL SHARE INFORMATION AND TALK, WHAT WE'LL RECHECK BEFORE ANY CHOICE (availability, staffing, what a setting can handle, and her needs at that time), and WHAT WE'VE AGREED NOT TO DO YET. Leave a signature line for each person, including your mother. Do not mention any provider or setting, predict her needs, or state who has legal authority to decide.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page every sibling would sign, and your mother would recognize herself in.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep a copy where each of you can find it, and set a date to reread it together.

The criteria come from your mother, not from the siblings

A family agreement about how to choose is only as good as its picture of your mother. The care interview organizes her current situation into a Family Care Profile, the file the family and your care consultant will come back to when a decision gets closer.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›